

# Sweating His Equity

The flamboyant Shashi Tharoor loses his ministry, credibility and much else as his IPL involvement brings the lively innings in South Block to a close

nation speech in Parliament on April 20. "My conscience is clear and I know that I have done nothing improper or unethical, let alone illegal. Nonetheless, I have no desire to be an embarrassment to the Government," he said in a hurt, accented tone.

An epitaph of embarrassment is not quite what he had crafted for himself when he first sauntered into Parliament 10 months ago, a first-time MP-turned-minister. Yet, he was left with very little editorial freedom to manoeuvre his politics. In fact, even his resignation speech was first vetted by Pranab Mukherjee who went through the four-page draft with a ruthless red pen and reduced it to a little over one page. Not used to his body of work being treated with such scant respect, the much-chastened Tharoor did not argue. He is slowly learning that the grammar of political India has more full-stops than it has exclamation marks. The prime minister too was equally keen to put, if not a full stop, at least a comma after Tharoor, especially in a ministry where Manmohan Singh had hoped to make all the headlines. According to a PMO official, when Tharoorgate came to light, a puzzled Manmohan, then in Washington, asked: "What is IPL?" The official added, "Perhaps he thought it was a

By Priya Sahgal and  
Saurabh Shukla

Shashi Tharoor once said on Twitter, "I have always wanted to play cricket very badly. And that's just what I did: I played cricket very badly." It seems his tweets and the game of cricket have come back to haunt the former minister of state for external affairs. Accused of

ministerial impropriety in his role relating to the IPL Kochi franchise, Tharoor, one of Manmohan Singh's most flamboyant ministers, was asked to submit his resignation as he had become an embarrassment to the Government. Ironically, though Tharoor had few supporters when he was a minister, he found many of his colleagues reaching out to him to shake hands after he had read out his resig-

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